

around and dreaming about ways to *luck* yourself into wealth is a lot easier than focusing on how to work your way into wealth. The thing is, what looks like luck to the outside world is usually the result of years—probably decades—of hard work. This isn't a new misperception, either. Two thousand years ago, the Roman philosopher Seneca observed, "Luck is what happens when preparation meets opportunity." My friend and mentor Dave Ramsey has a more down-home spin on this. He likes to joke, "I've been working my tail off for twenty-five years, but now I'm an 'overnight' success!" The problem is that people don't recognize the time and energy most millionaires put into building wealth. And forget the stereotypical "rich" entrepreneur or celebrity. Let's make it more personal. I want you to picture your next-door neighbors, just a regular couple with regular jobs in a regular house on a regular street. Nothing fancy about them. They wear jeans, drive old cars, have kids in public school, and do their own yardwork. Got the image in your head? Now, imagine finding out that this couple has \$3 million in their retirement account. What would be your first thought? Would you think about how they built their wealth slowly over time, or would you assume they had just received a big inheritance, filed a groundbreaking patent, or won a court settlement because of a random accident? Most people, in my experience, would assume there was a lightning-strike moment for the couple rather than thinking their wealth was the result of many years of discipline. One of these start-from-nothing, decades-in-the-making millionaires we talked to was Sandra, a retired police officer from Southern California.